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SUNSET UNDER WATER

Workers view a broken water main at Sunset Boulevard and Holloway Drive in West Hollywood that sent water gushing, closing many streets and highlighting L.A.’s aging infrastructure. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Voters support housing reform, poll says

Most favor changes to state environmental law to speed up building projects.

By NICOLE NIXON

A vast majority of California voters appear hungry to reform the state’s landmark environmental law to speed up housing and infrastructure projects, according to a newly released poll.

The findings, published Wednesday by the Public Policy Institute of California, come amid wide voter discontent with the price of entry into the state’s notoriously expensive housing market, and as residents feel increasingly squeezed by the cost of everyday essentials.

“The message from California voters is unmistakable: The status quo isn’t working, and we’re all paying the price,” Jennifer Barrera, California Chamber of Commerce president and chief executive, said in a statement about the polling.

The poll also showed that Californians have a strong distaste for building data centers for artificial intelligence technology — a hot-button topic that has been the subject of public protests and municipal bans across the state as residents and elected officials weigh the facilities’ potential economic benefits versus their power and water demands.

“Every day, we are hearing about how local communities across the nation are responding to plans for data centers,” said PPIC survey director Mark Baldassare. “Californians have weighed [See Poll, A7]

Cracking the code on cliff collapses

By ROSANNA XIA

Researchers have figured out how to develop hurricane warnings, tsunami warnings, even an earthquake early warning system. But when it comes to predicting cliff collapses along California’s iconic shoreline, the science has been infamously tricky to pin down.

But with every dramatic landslide and tragic death along the coast, officials have turned to scientists for help. Is it possible, many have wondered, to foresee when and where a bluff might collapse — and perhaps even turn these predictions into early warning alerts?

Now, after an innovative pilot study backed by decades of specialized research, scientists at UC San Diego’s Scripps Institution of Oceanography say

they may have cracked the code. In a report released this month, the team shared a proof of concept and found that there are remarkably reliable ways to detect a coastal landslide well before it happens.

The pilot study was able to predict five collapses at least several hours — sometimes even days — before they happened.

“It was surprising how good the data turned out to be, and how consistent it was for these types of landslides that we were monitoring,” said Adam Young, a coastal geomorphologist at Scripps who led the study. “We have a lot of confidence that what we’ve learned in San Diego could absolutely be applied to other places through- [See Cliffs, A8]



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ARCADIA was the ninth least affordable community in the L.A. Times’ analysis.

Sticker shock, high and low

These are the state’s most and least expensive cities

By TERRY CASTLEMAN

California is dotted with high-priced housing, from expansive compounds snapped up by the Silicon Valley titans in the hills above Stanford University to the prime beach spreads on the sand in Malibu.

But in some of the state’s

most elite communities, high prices are less of a barrier because the people who live there have equally high salaries.

By contrast, homes in gentrifying urban areas go for much less. But those prices might actually be further out of reach for many residents who had been living there well before the

boom.

The L.A. Times set out to rank the most and least affordable cities and towns in the state by the ratio of average home price to median household income level. Put another way, it’s the number of years of income it would take to buy the median home in a given area. [See Affordable, A12]

Democrats’ new strategy: It’s economics

Candidates zero in on affordability to win over voters before the November midterms.

By JUSTINE MCDANIEL

WASHINGTON — Democrats are making a growing effort to adopt a pragmatic focus as they campaign on affordability in the midterms, as some within the party push for moving away from ideological arguments.

Across the country, Democratic candidates are trying to win over voters by talking about real-life scenarios, framing other platform issues in economic terms and, strategists say, aiming to shift a perception that Democrats deal in the abstract.

They see an opening created by voters’ focus on the economy and their ability as the party not in power to leverage affordability as the key midterms issue as Trump’s economic approval remains low. Trump has dismissed the issue, calling affordability a “hoax” by Democrats while also promising economic improvements.

mic improvements.

“There has been a learning process in being able to take what Trump and the Republicans are doing and make sure that [candidates] are coming back to the real-world economic implications of whatever that might be,” said Democratic strategist Alex Jacquez, who served in the Biden White House. “That’s where maybe [Democrats] haven’t always, in the recent past, made the full connection all the way through.”

Now, “the moment is ripe,” he suggested, for the party to shift its image.

The Democrats’ concentration on affordability and the economy has defined their midterm messaging, playing off elevated inflation, the effects of Trump’s tariffs and high gas prices caused by the war in Iran. The party is attempting to capture enough swing voters to win a House majority in November, and some believe the Senate could also be within reach.

Polling shows pessimism about the economy has increased among all Americans and most believe the country is in an affordability [See Democrats, A7]

For fire survivors, yet another barrier

Mortgage lenders are withholding insurance funds allocated for home reconstruction.

By GRACE TOOHEY

More than a year after the Eaton fire devastated their community, returning to their beloved Altadena neighborhood finally seemed within reach for Baba Singh and his family.

They had secured their insurance payout, gotten rebuilding plans approved and hired a contractor.

But then their mortgage company started withholding the couple’s insurance money it held in escrow — allocated specifically for the rebuild. The inaccessible cash continues to threaten their family’s ability to continue construction.

“We’re literally being denied money that doesn’t belong to them,” Singh said of his mortgage company. “It’s just so demoralizing at this point.”

The frustrating situation comes on top of mounting financial strain and housing instability for many fire survivors who are trying to rebuild their homes and lives after the 2025 firestorms.

Local and state officials worry the mortgage payout delays could further stymie what’s become an already slow recovery.

This week, Gov. Gavin Newsom called on mortgage companies to better support fire victims, calling “survivors’ ability to access the insurance coverage they’ve paid for... foundational to recovery.”

“I am concerned that too many financial institutions are not providing fair and fast access to insurance proceeds,” Newsom wrote in a letter to associations representing California banks, credit unions and mortgage lenders. “The state has received dozens of reports of servicers holding funds in excess of the unpaid principal balance in clear violation of federal guidelines.”

Under most mortgage agreements, lenders have the authority to administer a home’s insurance payout, a process that is supposed to [See Barrier, A6]



ANNA MONEYMAKER Getty Images

SPEAKING TO NATION

President Trump was to give a prime-time address Thursday focused on his unfounded 2020 election claims. For coverage, visit latimes.com.

Open season in ocean preserves

Trump has allowed commercial fishing in some Pacific sanctuaries, reversing Obama’s order. **CLIMATE, A9**

Weather

Partly sunny. L.A. Basin: 85/68. **B6**

Markets **A12**
Opinion Voices **A13**

Netflix reports higher growth

Streamer beat analysts’ expectations on net income in the second quarter. **BUSINESS, A10**

For the latest news, go to latimes.com.



L.A.’s spookiest denizens are here to stay

By JACK FLEMMING

The undead are invading L.A.

They wear Santa hats and sunglasses, American flags and pool floaties. Some stand erect, towering over houses and neighborhoods. Others rot in the California sun, disintegrating into bony fragments. A pelvis atop two legs in a driveway. A skull peering over a rooftop.

They are, of course, giant 12-foot skeletons. And if they’re not in your neighborhood already, they probably will be soon.

Released by Home Depot



ARWEN CLEMANS Los Angeles Times

SKELLY, left, a 12-foot Halloween prop sold by Home Depot, towers over Fairfax Avenue. He’s not alone.

in 2020, the Halloween prop known as “Skelly” has transmogrified from a meme into a movement.

At first mostly limited to the month of October and maybe a week or two in November, many skeletons now stay up year-round as their proud owners deck them out with whatever theme fits the latest holiday: Christmas, Easter, the Fourth of July.

Some are political: a Putin skeleton puppeteering an undead Trump, or a skeleton with a sign that says “Not vaccinated, see you soon idiots!” Others are the [See Skeletons, A8]